MONEY MADE SIMPLE · FREE GUIDE

The 7-Day Money Reset

Seven 15-minute tasks that find your real numbers, stop surprise fees, protect your credit and give you one weekly spending number.

15 minutes a day | Printable checklist | Worksheets included | No apps required



Educational content. Not financial advice.

START HERE

How this works

Feeling behind with money usually isn't a number problem first. It's a visibility problem: you can't fix what you avoid looking at. This reset fixes visibility in a week.

1. **One task a day, about 15 minutes.** Do them in order; each day builds on the one before. Miss a day? Just do it tomorrow.
2. **Have your banking and card apps open.** Every task uses your real accounts, not estimates.
3. **Write on the worksheets.** Print this PDF, or copy the tables into a note. By Day 7 you'll have your numbers on one page.

The week at a glance

Day	Task	Done
Day 1	Find your real monthly take-home pay and list every fixed bill	☐
Day 2	Hunt down forgotten subscriptions; cancel what you don't use	☐
Day 3	Set three bank alerts that stop overdrafts and late fees	☐
Day 4	Open or check a separate, insured savings account; automate a first transfer	☐
Day 5	Pull your free credit reports, check them, and freeze your credit	☐
Day 6	Check you're getting your full 401(k) match (or note when you can start)	☐
Day 7	Set your one weekly spending number and book a 20-minute weekly check-in	☐

PLEASE READ

This is general education about organising your own money, not financial, tax, legal or investment advice. Examples use made-up numbers. US-specific references (FDIC, IRS, credit bureaus) are noted. If you're dealing with collections, tax debt or anything that feels unmanageable, a nonprofit credit counsellor (in the US, an NFCC member agency) is a good, low-cost next step.

DAY 1

Find your real numbers

Why: every plan starts with what actually lands in your account and what actually leaves it. Not your salary, not a guess.

A. Your monthly take-home pay

Look at your last two or three paychecks (the amount deposited, after tax and deductions).

- **Paid monthly:** use one paycheck.
- **Paid every two weeks:** one paycheck × 26 ÷ 12.
- **Paid weekly:** one paycheck × 52 ÷ 12.
- **Income varies:** use your *lowest* normal month from the last six.

```
My monthly take-home pay: $ ____________
```

B. Every fixed bill

Scroll the last 60 days of every bank and card account. Write down anything that repeats. Include yearly bills too, divided by 12.

Bill	Monthly $	Due date	Paid from
Rent / housing			
Utilities			
Phone / internet			
Insurance			
Minimum debt payments			
Transport (car payment, transit pass)			
Total fixed bills			

> **Tip:** note which account each bill comes from. Bills spread across several cards are how payments get missed.

☐ **Day 1 done: I know my take-home pay and my total fixed bills.**

DAY 2

Hunt down forgotten subscriptions

Why: subscriptions are designed to be easy to start and easy to forget. This is usually the fastest monthly saving you'll find.

1. **Search your statements** (last 90 days) for: *monthly, subscription, renewal, membership, recurring, premium, plus, pro*, and for "Apple", "Google" and "PayPal". Then scan 12 months for once-a-year charges.
2. **Check the app stores.** iPhone: Settings → your name → Subscriptions. Android: Play Store → profile → Payments & subscriptions → Subscriptions. PayPal: Settings → Payments → Manage automatic payments.
3. **Ask one question of each:** "If this weren't already running, would I sign up today at this price?" No → cancel now. Maybe → calendar reminder a week before the next charge. Yes → keep it, guilt-free.

Subscription	Monthly $	Keep / Cancel / Decide by
Saved per month by cancelling		

Hard to cancel? Cancel the way you signed up, screenshot the confirmation, and if charges continue, dispute them with your card issuer.

☐ **Day 2 done: every subscription is listed, and the ones I don't use are cancelled.**

DAY 3

Set three bank alerts

Why: you don't need a budgeting app to stop money surprises. Your accounts can tell you what's happening instead of you guessing. All three are free.

ALERT 1

Low balance

Set it at about one week of your normal spending, so you're warned while there's still time to move money.

ALERT 2

Large transaction

Around $50–$100. Catches fraud and impulse buys the moment they happen.

ALERT 3

Payment due

On every card and loan, 5 days before the due date. A payment that's 30 or more days late can be reported to the credit bureaus and stay on your report for years.

Find them in each bank or card app under **Settings**, **Notifications** or **Alerts**.

Bonus (5 minutes): turn on autopay for minimums

Set every card and loan to automatically pay at least the minimum. You can still pay more manually. Autopay is a safety net so a busy week never becomes a late payment.

Bonus: the two-account trick

If you keep checking your balance before buying lunch, try two checking accounts: **Bills** (receives an automatic transfer each payday for your fixed bills, never touched by a card) and **Spending** (everything else). Keep about one extra week of bills in Bills as a cushion for timing gaps.

Account	Low balance alert	Large transaction alert	Due-date alert	Autopay min.

☐ **Day 3 done: all three alerts are on, and minimums are on autopay.**

DAY 4

Give your savings a separate home

Why: a starter emergency fund turns a flat tire from a crisis into an errand. Money that sits in checking gets spent.

Check (or choose) your savings account

- [ ] **Separate from checking**, and not linked to your debit card.
- [ ] **Insured:** held at an FDIC-insured bank or NCUA-insured credit union (up to $250,000 per depositor, per institution, per ownership category). Using an app? Find its partner bank in the fine print and look it up in FDIC BankFind.
- [ ] **No monthly fees** and no minimum-balance traps.
- [ ] **A competitive rate.** High-yield savings accounts often pay far more than a standard savings account.
- [ ] **Easy transfers out**, within a day or two.

Automate your first transfer

Set an automatic transfer for the day after payday. Any amount you can keep up counts: $25 a week is $1,300 a year.

```
Automatic transfer: $ ________ every ____________ (day) into ____________
(account)
```

Your first target: $1,000

The long-term target is usually 3–6 months of essential expenses. Start with $1,000. At $125 a week, that's 8 weeks. Fast ways to get there: sell two things you haven't used in a year, send what you save from Day 2's cancelled subscriptions, and send one extra shift's pay straight to savings.

> **Rules for the fund:** real emergencies only (car repair, medical bill, urgent travel, job gap). Use it without guilt. Refill it before anything else.

☐ **Day 4 done: my savings account is separate and insured, and a transfer is automated.**

DAY 5

Check your credit, then freeze it

Why: credit reports can contain mistakes, and a free credit freeze makes it much harder for someone to open credit in your name. (US-specific.)

A. Get your free reports (5 minutes)

Go to **AnnualCreditReport.com**, the official site. Reports from Equifax, Experian and TransUnion are free, weekly. You don't need to pay or start a trial anywhere.

B. Check them like an auditor (5 minutes)

- [ ] Personal details: names, addresses and employers are all yours
- [ ] Every account: you recognise each one
- [ ] Status: open and closed accounts are correct
- [ ] Balances and credit limits are right (a missing limit can hurt your score)
- [ ] Payment history: no late payments you made on time
- [ ] No duplicate accounts or collections
- [ ] Hard inquiries: only applications you made

Found an error? Dispute it online with the bureau reporting it. Found an account that isn't yours? Go to **IdentityTheft.gov**.

C. Freeze your credit at all three bureaus (5 minutes)

Free by federal law. It doesn't affect your score or your existing cards. Lift it temporarily when you apply for credit.

Bureau	Where	Frozen	Login saved in
Equifax	equifax.com (search "credit freeze") · 1-888-298-0045	☐	
Experian	experian.com/freeze · 1-888-397-3742	☐	
TransUnion	transunion.com/credit-freeze · 1-888-909-8872	☐	

☐ **Day 5 done: reports checked, credit frozen at all three bureaus.**

DAY 6

Claim your 401(k) match

Why: many employers add money when you contribute to a workplace retirement plan. Not contributing enough to get the full match is turning down part of your pay.

How a common match works

A common formula is **50% of what you contribute, up to 6% of your pay**. On a $45,000 salary (example):

You contribute	You put in / year	Employer adds
0%	$0	$0
3%	$1,350	$675
6% (full match)	**$2,700**	**$1,350**

Your 10-minute check

- [ ] Log in to your plan's website (via your HR or benefits portal)
- [ ] Find the match formula and vesting schedule (or ask HR)
- [ ] Check your contribution rate is at least what's needed for the full match
- [ ] Check the money is actually invested (e.g. a target-date fund), not sitting in cash
- [ ] Can't afford the full match yet? Start lower and turn on an automatic 1% yearly increase, if offered

```
Match formula: __________   Rate needed: ____%   My rate now: ____%   Vesting:
__________
```

No workplace plan? Write down "IRA" as a next step. A Roth IRA is a common first account for people with earned income; contributions (not earnings) can come back out any time without tax or penalty. Check current limits at irs.gov.

☐ **Day 6 done: I know my match and I'm on track to get all of it (or I have a plan to start).**

DAY 7

Set your one weekly number

Why: budgets fail in week three because they ask you to police a dozen categories. Watch one number instead.

Split your take-home pay into four lines. Three run on autopilot; you only watch the fourth.

Line	What goes in it	Monthly $
Take-home pay	From Day 1	
− Bills	Day 1 total, minus Day 2 cancellations	
− Funds	Yearly-but-predictable costs ÷ 12 (car, gifts, renewals)	
− Goals	Day 4 savings transfer + any extra debt payment	
= Left for spending	**Groceries, eating out, fun, everything else**	

```
Weekly number = left for spending × 12 ÷ 52 = $ ________ a week
```

Example (fictional): $832 left for spending × 12 ÷ 52 = **$192 a week**. When it's gone, the week's done. Money left on Sunday rolls over or goes to a goal.

Book your 20-minute weekly check-in

Put a recurring event in your calendar, same day each week:

2 min	3 min	10 min	5 min
Check	**Decide**	**Look ahead**	**Improve**
How much of this week's number is left?	Roll over or move it to a goal	Birthdays, trips, bills in the next 2 weeks	Cancel, renegotiate or bump a goal by $10

☐ **Day 7 done: I have my weekly number and a check-in in my calendar.**

YOU DID IT

What happens next

In one week you've found your real numbers, plugged leaks, protected your credit, started saving automatically and set up a budget you can run in 20 minutes. Most people never do half of that.

Keep the momentum

- **Do your first weekly check-in** this weekend.
- **Watch your inbox:** one short email a week, each with one specific money move. Reply any time and tell us how the reset went. A human reads every reply.
- **Next big moves,** in a common order: full 401(k) match → pay down high-interest debt (avalanche or snowball) → grow the emergency fund to 3–6 months → invest more, for example in a Roth IRA with a low-cost index or target-date fund.

WANT THE FULL SYSTEM, DONE FOR YOU?

The 20-Minute Budget is a 14-page guide plus a spreadsheet (Excel, Google Sheets or Numbers) that turns Day 7 into a complete system: monthly plan, weekly check-in tab that handles overspend and rollover, sinking funds tracker, and a debt payoff planner comparing avalanche and snowball side by side. One payment, no subscription, 14-day refund.

Find it on our website under Products.

Free guides on the website

- How to make a budget you'll actually keep
- Sinking funds: stop "surprise" expenses wrecking your budget
- Debt avalanche vs snowball, with the real maths
- How to start investing with $100 a month

The fine print. Educational content only; not financial, tax, legal or investment advice. Examples are fictional and use assumed numbers. Rules, limits and phone numbers can change: check the official source. We use AI tools to help with visuals and drafts; a human checks the facts and approves everything. Free for personal use; please share the download page rather than the file.